A SURVEY REPORT ON

EMERGING TRENDS IN LOW-CODE APPLICATION DEVELOPMENT: A STUDY OF ZOHO CREATOR

Name: Vaideeshwari K
Roll No: 241401121

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Abstract

I started this survey expecting low-code platforms to be a fairly niche, IT-department topic. What I found instead is that they have quietly become one of the more consequential shifts in how everyday business software gets built. This report looks at where low-code application development stands in 2026, using Zoho Creator as the main example. It covers how artificial intelligence, embedded analytics, structured deployment environments, and stronger governance have gone from being nice-to-have extras to being basic expectations of any serious low-code platform. Zoho Creator is placed next to a handful of other well-known platforms to see where it genuinely holds up and where it does not. The report ends by looking ahead at where low-code tools, and Zoho Creator in particular, seem to be heading next.

The information used here comes from a mix of platform documentation, product release notes, independent review sites, and general industry commentary on low-code adoption, combined with a short hands-on look at Zoho Creator itself. It is written as a student survey rather than a formal market research study, so the emphasis throughout is on building a clear, honest picture rather than presenting exhaustive statistics.

Table of Contents

1. Introduction

2. Methodology

3. What Low-Code Means, and Where Zoho Creator Fits

4. Trends Reshaping Low-Code Platforms

5. How Zoho Creator Compares to Other Platforms

6. Where Zoho Creator Is Actually Being Used

7. Weighing the Benefits Against the Risks

8. What Comes Next

9. Conclusion

References

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1. Introduction

Software teams have dealt with the same bottleneck for years: too few developers, too many requests, and release cycles that move slower than the business around them. Low-code development did not appear to replace traditional programming — it showed up to relieve that pressure. By swapping large amounts of hand-written code for visual builders, reusable components, and configurable logic, low-code platforms let both trained developers and non-technical "citizen developers" put together working applications in a fraction of the usual time.

It is worth being honest about why this matters right now rather than five years ago. Businesses today expect internal tools — a leave-approval form, a service-tracking dashboard — to appear in days, not months. IT departments, meanwhile, are usually stretched across security, infrastructure, and a backlog of "real" projects. Low-code platforms exist in that gap. They are not trying to be a replacement for skilled engineering; they are trying to take the routine 80% of app-building off everyone's plate so that developers can focus on the harder 20%.

Analyst firms tracking this space expect the share of new business applications built on low-code platforms to keep climbing, with a growing proportion of that work happening outside formal IT departments altogether. This does not remove developers from the picture; it changes what they spend their time on. Instead of writing routine CRUD screens or basic forms by hand, professional developers increasingly focus on architecture, integration, security review, and the harder problems visual tools cannot solve alone.

Zoho Creator is one of the more mature players in this market. It positions itself as an AI-assisted, low-code platform capable of producing full web and mobile business applications through a drag-and-drop interface, while still allowing custom scripting for teams that need more control. This report uses Zoho Creator as a case study to understand both the platform itself and the broader direction low-code tools are moving in.

1.1 What This Survey Sets Out to Do

- Explain, in plain terms, what low-code development actually involves today.
- Identify the trends currently shaping low-code platforms as a category.
- Examine Zoho Creator's core features and how it has evolved recently.
- Compare Zoho Creator against a spread of other established low-code platforms.
- Weigh the practical benefits of low-code adoption against its real risks.
- Form a view on where low-code platforms, and Zoho Creator, are likely headed.

2. Methodology

This survey is based on secondary research rather than a formal industry study. I went through Zoho Creator's own product documentation and release notes to understand what the platform currently offers, cross-checked those claims against independent review platforms and general low-code commentary, and spent time inside a trial Zoho Creator account to see how a few of these features actually behave in practice rather than relying only on marketing descriptions.

Where this report makes comparative claims — for instance, rating platforms on ease of use or AI capability in the comparison chart later on — those figures are presented clearly as an illustrative, author's-assessment scale rather than as verified benchmark data, since no controlled testing was carried out across all five platforms. The intent is to give a fair, reasonably informed impression rather than to pass off personal judgement as hard statistics.

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2.1 Limitations

A few limitations are worth being upfront about. Hands-on testing was limited to a trial account of Zoho Creator, so deeper enterprise-tier features could only be reviewed through documentation rather than direct use. The competitor platforms were not tested hands-on at all, and their coverage in this report leans more heavily on published reviews and vendor material. Finally, the low-code market moves quickly — feature sets and pricing mentioned here reflect the situation as of 2026 and may have shifted by the time this is read.

3. What Low-Code Means, and Where Zoho Creator Fits

3.1 Defining Low-Code

Low-code development sits in the middle of a spectrum. At one end is traditional software development, where almost everything is hand-coded. At the other end is no-code development, where users cannot write any code at all and are limited entirely to what the platform's visual tools allow. Low-code platforms sit between the two: most of an application — its screens, data models, and everyday logic — is assembled visually, but developers keep the option to drop into a scripting layer whenever the built-in tools fall short.

3.2 Zoho Creator in Brief

Zoho Creator is a cloud-hosted platform from Zoho Corporation aimed at building custom business applications without requiring a large engineering team. It is used across a wide range of industries — healthcare, education, logistics, retail, and manufacturing among them — by both professional IT teams and business staff with little coding background. A single application built on Creator automatically adapts to desktop browsers as well as iOS and Android devices, so teams are not maintaining separate codebases for web and mobile.

Its toolkit centres on a visual form and page builder, a workflow engine for automating multi-step processes, a scripting language called Deluge for handling logic the visual tools cannot express, a library of pre-built templates for common business needs, and connectors into other Zoho products as well as external services. Much of the platform's value comes from how much of the underlying technical setup — hosting, database management, mobile packaging — it quietly handles on the developer's behalf, which is exactly what I noticed while exploring the platform's own admin dashboard: most of the heavy infrastructure decisions are simply made for you.

3.3 Where It Sits in the Market

Zoho Creator is consistently rated among the stronger platforms in independent low-code reviews, usually praised for its ease of use, workflow automation, cross-device support, and the depth of its data handling. Its pricing, which includes a free entry tier and scales per user, tends to make it more accessible to smaller organisations than some of the enterprise-first platforms it competes with. The chart below gives a rough sense of how adoption of low-code tools generally, as a category, has trended over the past few years.

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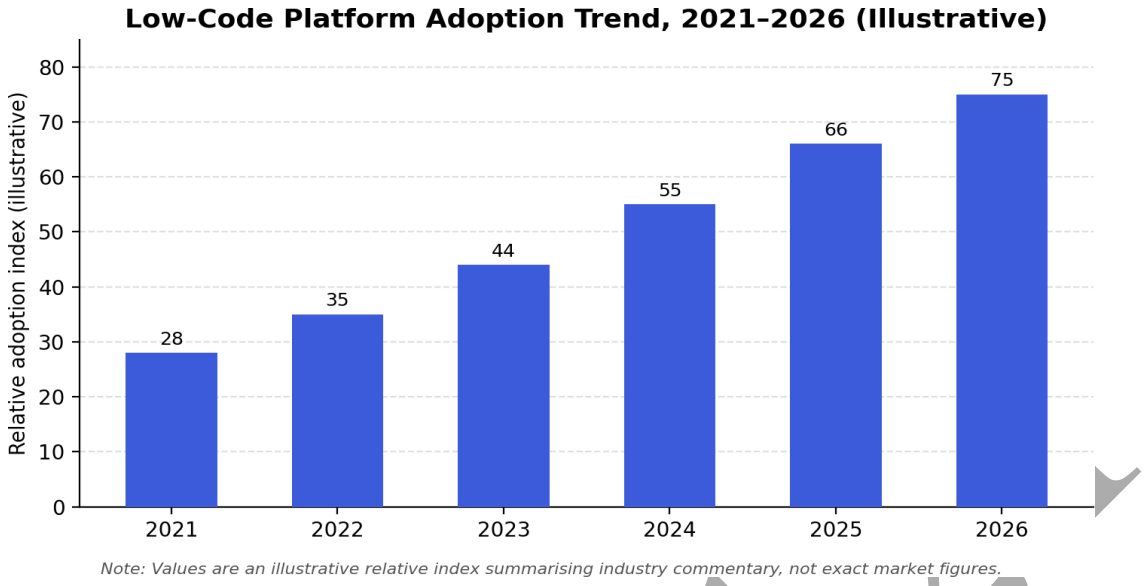


Figure 1: Illustrative low-code adoption trend, 2021–2026 (relative index based on industry commentary).

4. Trends Reshaping Low-Code Platforms

Low-code tools in 2026 look quite different from the drag-and-drop builders of a few years ago. The shift is less about the basic building blocks and more about how much intelligence, oversight, and built-in tooling now sits around them. The trends below draw on recent platform updates and general industry commentary, and are grouped roughly in the order they seem to be maturing.

4.1 Building Apps by Describing Them

A growing number of platforms let users describe what they want in ordinary language and have the system generate a first working draft — a form, a report, or an entire workflow. Zoho Creator's own AI assistant, Zia, follows this pattern, turning plain-language requests into a starting structure that a builder then refines, rather than requiring every field and layout to be placed by hand from the outset. It is not perfect — AI-generated first drafts still need a human to check the logic — but it noticeably cuts down the blank-page problem.

4.2 Agents That Act, Not Just Answer

Beyond chat-style assistants, platforms are introducing AI agents that can carry out multi-step tasks with limited human input — checking a record, updating a workflow, and notifying the right person, for instance. Zoho frames its broader platform strategy, referred to internally as AppOS, around this idea: Creator and its companion automation tool Zoho Flow become components that AI agents can operate within, under rules set by the business. Analysts are quick to note that many early agent deployments underperform when they are not carefully scoped and monitored, which keeps human oversight relevant even as automation grows.

4.3 Analytics Living Inside the App

Rather than exporting data to a separate business-intelligence tool, platforms are folding analytics directly into the application layer. Zoho Creator now supports things like predictive trend detection, automated alerts on unusual data, scenario or what-if modelling, and the ability to ask questions about a dataset in plain language and get a chart or number back, without leaving the app.

4.4 Proper Environments, Not Just One Live App

As low-code apps move from side projects to systems the business depends on, platforms have adopted practices borrowed from traditional software engineering. Zoho Creator supports separate development, staging, and production spaces, with the ability to promote a tested change from one stage to the next without disrupting whatever end users are currently working in. This is one of the more “grown-up” features on the platform, and it is easy to underestimate how important it is until you have actually broken a live app by editing it directly.

4.5 Tighter Governance as More People Build

With more non-technical staff building apps directly, platforms have had to strengthen the controls sitting around that freedom — granular permissions, audit trails, backup and recovery, and centralised dashboards for managing users and spend. The pattern across the industry is consistent: business users build, but IT retains oversight of standards, security, and how systems connect to one another.

4.6 Templates Built for Specific Industries

Many platforms, Zoho Creator included, now ship with libraries of ready-made applications aimed at particular jobs — field service scheduling, procurement approvals, compliance logging, HR onboarding — so a team can start from something close to what they need rather than an empty canvas.

4.7 A Shifting Line Between Developer and Business User

As AI absorbs more of the repetitive, boilerplate coding work, professional developers are spending comparatively more time on system design, integration, and judgement calls that tools cannot make, while business users take on more of the routine app-building themselves. Most industry commentary frames this as a change in emphasis for developers rather than a reduction in their importance, and that distinction matters — it is easy to read “low-code” as a threat to developer jobs when the more accurate story is a shift in what those jobs actually involve.

4.8 How the Pieces Fit Together

It helps to see all of this laid out visually. The diagram below sketches how a typical Zoho Creator application is structured — from the different types of users accessing it, through the platform's core building blocks, down to where data is stored and how it eventually surfaces as analytics.

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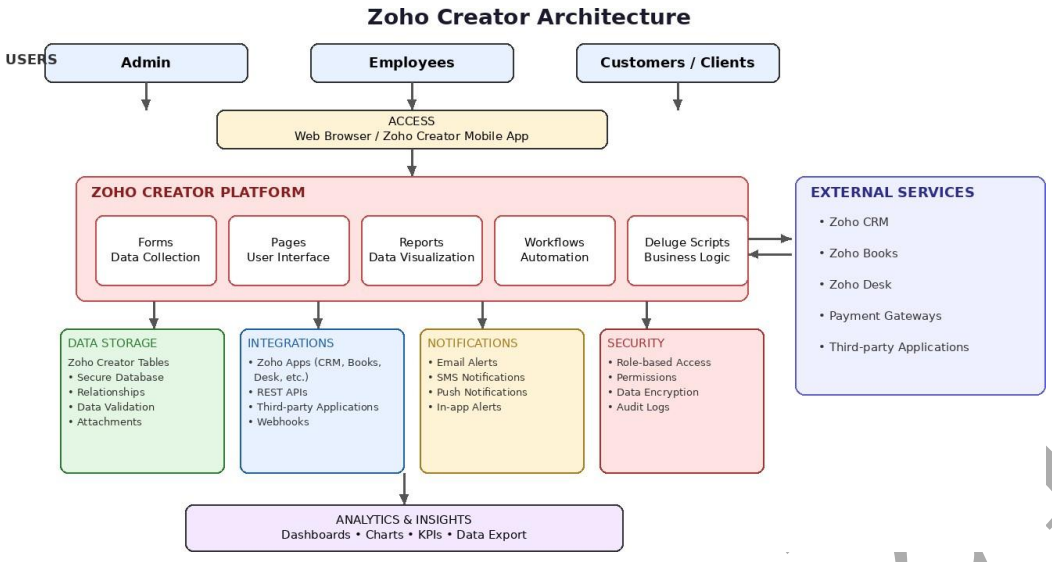


Figure 2: A simplified view of Zoho Creator's application architecture.

5. How Zoho Creator Compares to Other Platforms

No single low-code platform is the right choice for every situation, and Zoho Creator is no exception. The table below sets it against a small spread of well-known alternatives, chosen to represent different corners of the market — suite-integrated tools, enterprise-scale platforms, process-automation specialists, and lighter web-app builders.

Platform	Where It Stands Out	Approach to AI	Who It Suits Best
Zoho Creator	Tight integration with the wider Zoho One suite; analytics built into the app itself	Zia-powered assistance for building forms, workflows and reports from plain text prompts	Small and mid-sized businesses, and teams already inside the Zoho ecosystem
Microsoft Power Apps	Native fit with Microsoft 365, Teams and Azure services	Copilot Studio for building conversational agents on top of apps	Enterprises already standardised on the Microsoft stack
OutSystems	High-performance architecture built for large, mission-critical systems	AI-assisted code scaffolding and automated testing	Large enterprises with strict scalability and compliance needs
Appian	Process automation and case management at its core	Built-in process-mining and AI-driven decisioning	Regulated industries needing auditable workflow control
Bubble	Full visual control over web-app front ends without a traditional dev stack	AI-assisted layout and logic suggestions	Startups and solo builders creating customer-facing web products

What differentiates Zoho Creator most clearly is its position inside Zoho One. Applications built on Creator connect to Zoho CRM, Zoho Books, Zoho Flow, and dozens of other Zoho products with little additional setup, which makes it a natural choice for organisations already using those tools. Platforms such as OutSystems and

Appian, by contrast, tend to be selected by larger organisations with more demanding scalability, compliance, or process-governance requirements, while a tool like Bubble is better suited to smaller, front-end-heavy web products than to internal, data-heavy business systems.

To make that comparison a little more concrete, the radar chart below plots Zoho Creator against two of its closest competitors — OutSystems and Power Apps — across five practical dimensions. As mentioned in the methodology, these ratings reflect a reasonably informed personal assessment rather than a formal benchmark, but the overall shape of each platform's strengths and weaknesses lines up with what most independent reviews describe.

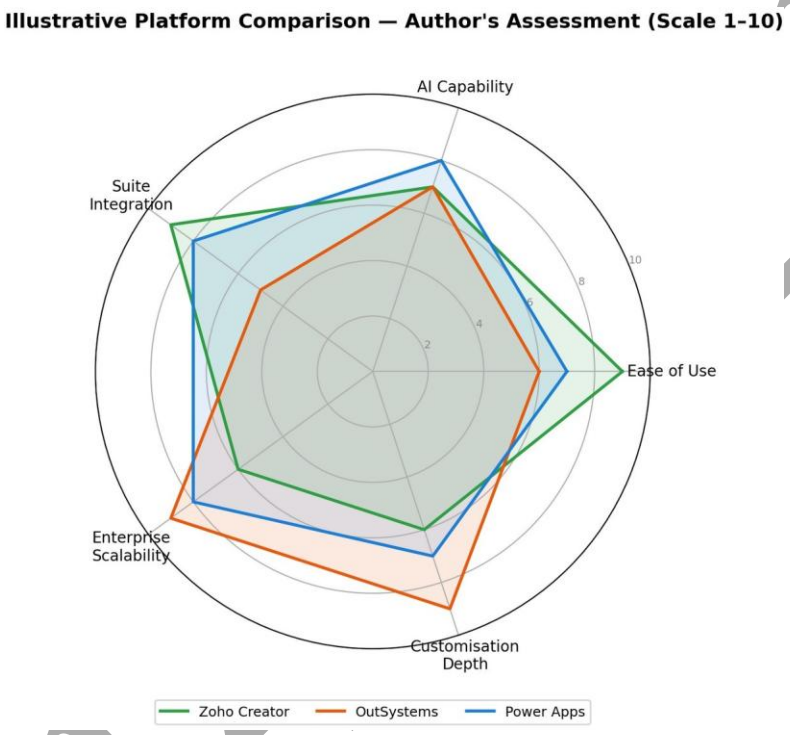


Figure 3: Illustrative comparison of Zoho Creator, OutSystems, and Power Apps across five criteria.

6. Where Zoho Creator Is Actually Being Used

The following examples illustrate the kinds of problems teams commonly solve with Zoho Creator in practice.

6.1 Field Service Coordination

Service businesses use Creator to assign jobs to technicians, capture customer sign-off on-site, and update job status as work happens, with mobile support that continues to function when a connection drops and picks up location data automatically.

6.2 Procurement and Expense Approvals

Multi-step approval chains and budget checks are automated end to end, cutting down on manual reconciliation and giving finance teams a cleaner trail to work from when audit season arrives.

6.3 Branded Client Portals

Organisations build secure, self-service portals where external clients can view reports, log support requests, or check on project progress without needing an internal team member to intervene each time.

6.4 Compliance Record-Keeping

In tightly regulated sectors such as pharmaceuticals and financial services, custom Creator apps are used to log compliance data and flag it automatically against internal policy and external regulatory requirements.

6.5 HR Processes

Onboarding checklists, leave requests, and performance review cycles are consolidated into a single app, replacing the usual sprawl of spreadsheets and email threads that HR teams tend to accumulate.

7. Weighing the Benefits Against the Risks

7.1 What Low-Code Adoption Tends to Deliver

- Noticeably faster app delivery compared with building everything from scratch by hand.
- Less dependence on scarce, specialised developer talent for everyday business applications.
- Closer, faster collaboration between business teams and IT, working from the same visual model.
- One build that runs across web and mobile, removing the need for parallel development tracks.
- Ready-made connections to existing business systems, cutting down custom integration work.

7.2 Where the Risks Sit

- Vendor lock-in, since migrating a large app off a closed platform is rarely straightforward.
- Limits on customisation for highly specialised or performance-critical requirements.
- The risk of "shadow IT", where apps get built and used without proper security review.
- Over-reliance on AI-generated logic, particularly with autonomous agent features, without enough testing.
- Possible contraction in demand for purely routine, repetitive coding roles over time.

None of these risks are reasons to avoid low-code platforms altogether — they are reasons to use them deliberately, with someone in the organisation still responsible for reviewing what gets built and how it is secured.

8. What Comes Next

Most forecasts agree that low-code platforms are moving from a supporting role in enterprise IT toward a central one, with a growing share of important business applications expected to depend on them rather than on custom-built software from the ground up.

For Zoho Creator specifically, the more likely developments include deeper AI agent capability under its AppOS strategy, stronger audit and control mechanisms wrapped around those AI features to avoid the failure patterns seen in poorly governed agent projects elsewhere, and an analytics engine that surfaces useful insight with less manual configuration. More broadly, the gap between "low-code" and "AI-driven development" looks set to keep narrowing, to the point where describing an application in plain language may become the default starting point for building one, rather than a novelty feature layered on top.

It is also worth watching how competition plays out among the major suite-linked platforms. Zoho, Microsoft, and Salesforce are all pushing their low-code tools closer to their respective ecosystems, which suggests the platform decision for many companies may increasingly be driven by which productivity suite they already use, rather than by a feature-by-feature comparison of the low-code tools themselves.

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9. Conclusion

Low-code development has moved well past its early reputation as a shortcut for small internal tools. Between AI-assisted building, embedded analytics, environment-based deployment, and stronger governance, today's platforms are capable of far more than their earlier versions, and are being trusted with correspondingly more important work. Zoho Creator reflects this shift clearly: an accessible visual builder at its core, now surrounded by AI, analytics, and control features, and tied closely into a much larger family of business applications.

Coming into this survey, I expected to find a fairly simple drag-and-drop tool. What I actually found was a platform that has grown up considerably — closer to a small application platform than a form builder. As organisations continue to face developer shortages and long-standing IT backlogs, platforms built this way are likely to take on an even larger share of how business software gets built.

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